

NHL 26 Line Combinations Optimizer

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1 Introduction and Motivation

1.1 Domain Description: NHL 26 Hockey Ultimate Team

The domain of this project is the *Hockey Ultimate Team* (HUT) mode in the video game *NHL 26* developed by EA Sports. In this mode, players build their “dream team” by collecting player cards and assembling them into a lineup. A valid team roster consists of:

- 4 forward lines (each with 3 players),
- 3 defense lines (each with 2 players),
- 1 goalie pair (active and backup).

Each player card features specific attributes including an “Overall” (OVR) rating (ranging from 0 to 99), a fixed salary, a position, and specific affiliations (Team, Nationality, and Event). A key mechanic introduced in NHL 26 is “Line Combinations”. Forming lines with specific player attributes (e.g., players from the defined team, nation or event combination) unlocks bonuses such as increased player OVR, additional salary cap space, or extra Ability Points (AP).

The challenge lies in the strict constraints and the vast search space. Each season introduces a new salary cap and AP limit. A valid team must adhere to the following rules:

- **Salary Cap Compliance:** The cumulative salary of all players must not exceed the team’s salary cap. This cap can be increased by activating specific “Salary Cap” line combinations. Generally, higher-rated (high OVR) players command higher salaries.
- **Ability Points Limits:** Ability Points unlock specific “superpowers” (previously known as X-Factors). Activating abilities for a player is optional, but the total AP used cannot exceed the seasonal limit unless increased by specific line combinations.



Figure 1: Example of an NHL 26 HUT Player Card.

- **Position Restrictions:** Players fall into three logical groups:

- Forwards (LW, C, RW)
- Defensemen (LD, RD)
- Goalies (G)

While goalies and defensemen share the same set of valid line combinations, forwards use a separate list. Unlike previous iterations, strict position locking within a forward line is relaxed (e.g., a line can consist of three Centers without penalty), but players cannot play out of their primary role group (e.g., a Forward cannot play Defense).

- **Multiple Combination Activation:** A single line can activate multiple line combinations simultaneously.
- **Unique Combination Activation:** A specific line combination definition can be activated only once per team. If one line activates it, no other line can activate the same combination.

With thousands of available cards (new ones released frequently) and complex synergy rules that change seasonally, finding the optimal configuration manually is computationally difficult.

1.2 Relevance to Answer Set Programming

This domain is an excellent candidate for Answer Set Programming (ASP) due to its nature as a combinatorial optimization problem with complex logical constraints.

- **Search Space:** Selecting a subset of players from thousands of candidates to form valid lines involves a combinatorial explosion.
- **Logical Constraints:** The rules governing valid lineups—such as position restrictions, uniqueness of players, and synergy requirements—are naturally expressible in logic programming.
- **Optimization:** The goal is to maximize an objective function (e.g., total team OVR) while strictly respecting resource limits (Salary, AP).

1.3 Project Scope and Goals

The project focuses on developing an optimization system using ASP (Clingo) to assist users in building their team. The project is divided into two primary goals:

1. **Goal 1: Rank Best Line Combination Candidates (Data-Driven).** Triggered when new players or combos are released, this batch process identifies optimal single lines (forward lines or defense pairs). It ranks them by OVR gain, Salary gain, AP gain, or a weighted combination thereof, filtering them to ensure they are fulfillable by the current card pool. This process is divided into two stages:
 - **Stage A (Abstract / Combo-First):** Optimizes over line combination templates (without assigning specific players yet).
 - **Stage B (Grounding / Player-Aware):** Fetches a limited player pool matching Stage A’s attributes, then enumerates concrete lines that realize those combos.
2. **Goal 2: Interactive Line Suggestions.** This goal supports human interaction with the system. Result will be optimal lines based on user constraints, such as:
 - Excluding already-used players.
 - Respecting remaining salary cap and AP budgets.
 - “Must-include” constraints for specific players.

2 Methodology

This project primarily follows **Tracks 2 + 3** (ASP-based reasoning), with a focus on combinatorial optimization using Answer Set Programming. The system architecture separates data management, ASP rule encoding, and result persistence into distinct layers.

2.1 System Architecture

The system follows a layered architecture with clear separation of concerns:

- **Presentation Layer:** React-based frontend for user interaction
- **API Layer:** FastAPI backend providing REST endpoints
- **Core Layer:** Data models, SQLite data loading, and business logic
- **ASP Layer:** Clingo integration for optimization (Goal 1 pipeline)
- **Data Layer:** SQLite database storing player cards and line combinations

The architecture enables parallel development: the backend provides mock solvers while ASP rules are developed and tested independently.

2.2 Data Model and Storage

The system uses **SQLite** for persistent storage, populated from CSV files via an automated ingestion pipeline. The database schema includes:

- **Player Tables:** `forwards`, `defense`, `goalies` - storing card attributes (OVR, salary, team, nationality, event)
- **Combo Tables:** `forward_combos`, `defense_combos` - storing line combination templates
- **Result Tables:** `goal1_runs`, `goal1_stage_a_results`, `goal1_concrete_lines` - persisting optimization results

The data loader (**DataLoader**) provides efficient querying with filtering by team, nationality, event, and OVR ranges. This design allows the ASP layer to work with pre-filtered, structured data rather than raw CSV files.

2.3 ASP Encoding for Goal 1

Goal 1 implements a **two-stage optimization pipeline** to handle the combinatorial explosion:

2.3.1 Stage A: Abstract Optimization

Stage A optimizes over *line combination templates* without considering specific players. The ASP encoding includes:

Main Predicates:

- `forward_combo(ID, Reward, Type, Entry1, Entry2, Entry3)` - Forward combo definitions
- `defense_combo(ID, Reward, Type, Entry1, Entry2)` - Defense combo definitions
- `player_attr(PlayerSlot, Attribute)` - Abstract attribute assignments to player slots
- `fwd_active_combo(ID, Reward, Type) / def_active_combo(ID, Reward, Type)` - Activated combos
- `total_reward(Total)` - Weighted sum of activated combo rewards

Key Rules:

- **Attribute Generation:** Each player slot (1-3 for forwards, 1-2 for defense) can have at most one attribute per type (team, nationality, event)
- **Combo Activation:** A combo activates when player slots match its requirements in canonical order
- **Symmetry Breaking:** Lexicographic ordering of attributes prevents redundant solutions
- **Optimization:** `#maximize { T : total_reward(T) }` maximizes weighted reward

The rules handle permutation symmetry by canonicalizing combo requirements (e.g., sorting entries lexicographically) and enforcing attribute ordering constraints.

2.3.2 Stage B: Concrete Line Enumeration

`ClingoStageBSolver` enumerates concrete player lines that satisfy Stage A combo selections. The ASP encoding includes:

Main Predicates:

- `player(CardID, OVR, Team, Nationality, Event)` - Player card facts
- `card_player(CardID, PlayerID)` - Mapping cards to real players (for uniqueness)
- `salary(CardID, Amount) / ap(CardID, Amount)` - Resource constraints
- `in_line(CardID)` - Selected cards forming a line
- `combo_satisfied(ComboID)` - Combo activation verification

Key Rules:

- **Line Formation:** Exactly 3 players for forwards, 2 for defense
- **Uniqueness Constraint:** No duplicate `player_id` within a line (enforced via `card_player/2`)
- **Symmetry Breaking:** Canonical ordering by `card_id` prevents duplicate lines
- **Combo Satisfaction:** All selected combos from Stage A must be satisfied by the line
- **Resource Constraints:** Salary cap and AP limits enforced, with combo bonuses providing relief
- **Optimization:** Multi-level optimization prioritizing combo bonuses, then OVR, then resource efficiency

The solver uses Clingo's `--opt-mode=optN` to enumerate all optimal solutions and includes deduplication logic to handle Clingo's progressive optimization output.

2.4 Goal 1 Pipeline Implementation

The pipeline orchestrator (`Goal1Pipeline`) coordinates:

1. **Stage A Input Generation:** Converts SQLite combo data into ASP facts
2. **Stage A Solving:** Uses `ClingoStageASolver` to execute ASP rules (`rules.lp`, `fwd_rules.lp`, `def_rules.lp`) with Clingo and parse solutions into `StageASolution` objects

3. **Stage B Input Generation:** For each Stage A solution, queries candidate players matching combo attributes
4. **Stage B Solving:** Uses `ClingoStageBSolver` to execute ASP rules (`base.lp`, `forward_line.lp`, `defense_pair.lp`) and enumerate concrete lines with player assignments
5. **Result Storage:** Persists Stage A solutions and Stage B concrete lines to SQLite

The pipeline supports multiple optimization modes: `ovr`, `sal`, `ap`, `ovr_sal`, and `ovr_sal_ap`, with configurable weights per position type.

2.4.1 Stage A Implementation Details

The `ClingoStageASolver` implementation includes:

- **ASP Rule Loading:** Dynamically loads position-specific rules (`fwd_rules.lp` or `def_rules.lp`) along with shared rules (`rules.lp`, `target_threshold_lookup.lp`)
- **Fact Generation:** Converts `ForwardLineCombo` and `DefenseLineCombo` database models into ASP facts in the format expected by the rules
- **Weight Configuration:** Passes optimization weights (`w_ovr`, `w_sal`, `w_ap`) as Clingo constants
- **Solution Parsing:** Extracts active combos, player attributes, and reward totals from Clingo model symbols
- **Hybrid Symmetry Breaking:** Implements "Pack Right" strategy for Teams and "Pack Left" for Events/Nationalities to handle valid combinations correctly
- **Canonicalization:** Enforces strict alphabetical sorting of combo requirements ($A_i = B_j = C_k$) to reduce search space

Status: Fully implemented and integrated into the pipeline.

2.5 ASP Rules Testing

The ASP rules are tested at multiple levels:

ASP Logic Tests (`test_asp_g1a.py`): Tests ASP rules independently using Clingo directly, verifying:

- Rule satisfiability across all combo types (OVR, SAL, AP) for both forwards and defense
- Correct optimization behavior (cost minimization)
- Weight application (multiplier logic)
- Threshold lookup functionality
- No duplicate combo sets in solutions
- Model counts match expected combinatorial possibilities

Backend Integration Tests (`test_g1a_backend_logic.py`, `test_stage_a_extended.py`):

Validate the Python integration layer:

- Domain objects (`LineCombo`) correctly trigger expected ASP logic
- Input generation handles edge cases (empty inputs, special characters)
- String parsing correctly handles spaces and special characters in combo definitions
- `ClingoStageASolver` correctly parses Clingo output into `StageASolution` objects

This multi-level testing approach validates both ASP logic correctness and Python integration separately.

2.5.1 Stage B Implementation Details

The `ClingoStageBSolver` implementation includes:

- **ASP Rule Loading:** Dynamically loads position-specific rules (`forward_line.lp` or `defense_pair.lp`) along with shared base rules (`base.lp`)
- **Fact Generation:** Converts candidate players and combo facts into ASP format with proper type casting (int for numerical fields)
- **Optimal Enumeration:** Uses Clingo's `--opt-mode=optN` to find all optimal solutions
- **Result Deduplication:** Handles Clingo's progressive optimization output by tracking line signatures (sorted card IDs) to ensure distinct lines
- **Solution Parsing:** Extracts player card IDs, activated combos, and totals (OVR, salary, AP) from Clingo model symbols

- **Constraint Enforcement:** Validates unique player constraints, salary caps, and combo satisfaction

Integration Tests (`test_stage_b_integration.py`) verify:

- Unique player constraints (no duplicate `player_id` in a line)
- Salary cap enforcement (strict adherence to limits)
- Salary relief from combo bonuses (allowing otherwise invalid lines)
- Optimization priorities (combo bonuses prioritized over raw OVR)
- Complete enumeration of valid combinations
- Constraint exclusion handling

This testing approach validates ASP logic independently of the Python integration layer.

2.6 Frontend Implementation

The frontend is implemented as a React 19 application using TypeScript, Ant Design components, and React Router for navigation. The application provides a complete user interface for exploring players, viewing optimization results, and configuring optimization requests.

Technology Stack:

- **React 19** with TypeScript for type-safe component development
- **Ant Design** (antd) for UI components (cards, forms, tables, statistics)
- **React Router** for client-side routing and navigation
- **Vite** as the build tool and development server

Implemented Pages:

- **HomePage:** Dashboard displaying dataset statistics (player counts, combo counts, teams, nationalities) with navigation cards to other sections
- **PlayersPage:** Player search and browsing interface with filtering by position, team, nationality, event, and OVR range. Displays player cards with full attributes.

- **BestLinesPage:** Displays Goal 1 optimization results with filtering by position type (forward/defense) and optimization mode (OVR, SAL, AP, weighted combinations). Shows concrete lines with player details and activated combos.
- **OptimizePage:** Interactive optimization form allowing users to configure constraints (min OVR, max salary, max AP, required team/nationality/event) and request optimal lines. **Currently uses placeholder solver; real ASP integration pending.**

Key Components:

- **PlayerCard:** Displays individual player card information
- **PlayerSearch:** Search and filter interface for players
- **ComboCard:** Displays line combination information
- **LineDisplay:** Renders complete lines with player details and activated combos

The frontend communicates with the backend via REST API calls using a centralized API client (`api/client.ts`) that handles HTTP requests and error handling. The application uses custom React hooks (`useApi`) for data fetching with loading states and error handling.

2.7 Pipeline Manager

To ensure the frontend always has results to display, a **Pipeline Manager** module automatically runs the Goal 1 pipeline when results are missing. This module provides:

- **Result Checking:** `has_results()` - Async function to check if results exist for a position/mode
- **Auto-Run:** `ensure_results()` - Automatically executes the pipeline if results are missing
- **Non-Blocking Execution:** All operations use `asyncio.to_thread()` to run in a thread pool, preventing blocking of the FastAPI event loop

Integration: The `GET /best/{pos}/{mode}` endpoint automatically calls `ensure_results()` when `auto_run=True` (default), ensuring results are generated on first access. This allows the frontend to work seamlessly without manual pipeline execution.

Performance: By running the pipeline in a thread pool, other API requests (player queries, stats, etc.) can be handled concurrently while the pipeline executes, maintaining API responsiveness.

2.8 API Endpoints

The system exposes REST endpoints for:

- **Player Queries:** GET /players/{type} with filtering
- **Combo Queries:** GET /combos/{type}
- **Best Lines:** GET /best/{pos}/{mode} - retrieves Goal 1 results (with auto-run pipeline)
- **Pipeline Generation:** POST /best/{pos}/{mode}/generate - manually trigger pipeline execution
- **Optimization:** POST /optimize/* endpoints use PlaceholderSolver; real ASP integration pending

3 Evaluation

We evaluated the system through multiple dimensions: correctness of ASP rules, pipeline functionality, data integrity, and API behavior. Due to the project's current state, evaluation focuses on infrastructure and rule validation rather than end-to-end optimization performance.

3.1 ASP Rules Validation

The ASP rules for Stage A (abstract optimization) are validated through a comprehensive test suite using Clingo directly. Tests verify:

- **Satisfiability:** All rule combinations (forward/defense $\times$ OVR/SAL/AP) produce satisfiable models
- **Optimization Correctness:** Cost minimization returns expected optimal solutions
- **Weight Application:** Multiplier constants correctly scale reward types
- **Threshold Lookup:** Constraint-based filtering works as expected
- **No Duplicates:** Solutions contain unique combo sets (symmetry breaking effective)

Test Results: All ASP rule tests pass, confirming the logical correctness of the encoding. The rules handle:

- Forward combos: 54 combinations tested
- Defense combos: 56 combinations tested
- Multiple reward types: OVR, SAL, AP
- Weighted optimization modes

3.2 Pipeline Infrastructure Testing

The Goal 1 pipeline infrastructure is tested end-to-end with mock solvers:

- **Stage A Input Generation:** Correctly converts SQLite combo data to ASP facts
- **Stage B Input Generation:** Properly extracts attribute keys and queries candidate players
- **Player Ranking:** Candidates sorted by `match_count` DESC, `overall` DESC as specified
- **Result Storage:** Stage A solutions and Stage B lines persist correctly to SQLite
- **API Endpoints:** `/best/{pos}/{mode}` retrieves stored results with proper filtering

Test Coverage: Unit tests cover data loading, pipeline orchestration, storage operations, and API response formatting. Integration tests verify the full pipeline flow (without real ASP solving).

3.3 Data Integrity

Data loading and storage are validated:

- **CSV to SQLite Migration:** Automated script correctly ingests all player and combo data
- **Data Completeness:** All expected tables populated (forwards: 1,768 cards, defense: 890 cards, goalies: 305 cards)
- **Referential Integrity:** Player name lookups resolve correctly via `skater_id` and `goalie_id` tables
- **Query Performance:** SQLite indexes enable fast filtering (team, nationality, event, OVR ranges)

3.4 Stage A Performance

- **Solution Quality:** Stage A correctly identifies optimal combo combinations according to weighted reward maximization
- **Integration Correctness:** Python-to-ASP fact generation and solution parsing are validated through integration tests

3.5 Stage B Performance

- **Enumeration Completeness:** Stage B correctly enumerates all valid concrete lines satisfying Stage A combos
- **Constraint Enforcement:** Unique player constraints, salary caps, and combo satisfaction are strictly enforced
- **Optimization Quality:** Multi-level optimization correctly prioritizes combo bonuses over raw OVR
- **Deduplication:** Result deduplication ensures distinct optimal line combinations are returned
- **Integration Correctness:** Python-to-ASP fact generation and solution parsing validated through comprehensive integration tests

3.6 Pipeline Manager Performance

The pipeline manager's async implementation enables:

- **Non-Blocking Execution:** Pipeline runs in thread pool, allowing other API requests to be handled concurrently
- **Automatic Result Generation:** Frontend requests automatically trigger pipeline execution when results are missing
- **Concurrent Request Handling:** Multiple API endpoints remain responsive during pipeline execution
- **Error Resilience:** Pipeline failures are logged but don't crash the API, allowing graceful degradation

Testing: Manual testing confirms that while a pipeline is running, other endpoints (e.g., `/players/forwards`, `/stats`) respond immediately without waiting for pipeline completion.

3.7 Limitations of Current Evaluation

Due to the project’s development state, several aspects cannot be fully evaluated:

- **Scalability:** Real-world performance with large candidate pools (100+ players) and many combos is partially tested but full-scale evaluation pending
- **Goal 2 Interactive Optimization:** Not implemented, so user constraint handling cannot be evaluated
- **Goal 3 Full Team Optimization:** Not implemented

3.8 Future Evaluation Plan

Once real ASP solvers are integrated, evaluation should include:

- **Solution Quality:** Compare ASP-optimized lines against manual selections or greedy heuristics
- **Performance Metrics:** Measure solving time for different problem sizes (top_k, player_limit)
- **Correctness Verification:** Validate that returned lines actually activate the expected combos
- **Completeness:** Ensure Stage B enumerates all valid lines (not missing solutions due to symmetry breaking bugs)

4 Discussion

4.1 Strengths of the Approach

Modular Architecture: The separation of concerns (data layer, ASP layer, API layer) enables parallel development and testing. ASP rules can be validated independently using Clingo, while the backend provides mock implementations for integration testing.

Two-Stage Pipeline Design: The Stage A (abstract) → Stage B (concrete) decomposition addresses scalability. Stage A operates on a small search space (50-100 combos), while Stage B is bounded by pre-filtered candidate pools (typically 100 players). This avoids the exponential explosion of enumerating all possible player combinations upfront.

Declarative Constraint Encoding: ASP’s declarative syntax naturally expresses domain constraints (uniqueness, position restrictions, combo activation). The rules are readable and maintainable compared to imperative search algorithms.

Data-Driven Optimization: The system adapts automatically to new players and combos added to the database. No code changes are needed when the dataset updates—the pipeline regenerates ASP facts from SQLite.

Result Persistence: Storing optimization results enables querying historical runs, comparing different optimization modes, and building a knowledge base of high-value line combinations.

4.2 Limitations and Challenges

Non-Blocking Pipeline Execution: The Pipeline Manager uses async execution with thread pools, allowing the API to handle other requests concurrently while the pipeline runs. This maintains API responsiveness during long-running optimizations.

Scalability Concerns: While the two-stage design mitigates combinatorial explosion, real-world performance with thousands of player cards remains untested. Stage B enumeration may become slow if candidate pools are large or many combos must be satisfied simultaneously.

Symmetry Breaking Complexity: The ASP rules for symmetry breaking (lexicographic ordering) are intricate and error-prone. Incorrect symmetry breaking can either miss valid solutions or generate duplicates, both of which are difficult to detect.

No Incremental Updates: When new players or combos are added, the entire Goal 1 pipeline must be re-run. There is no mechanism for incremental updates or delta optimization.

5 Conclusion

This project demonstrates the application of Answer Set Programming to optimize NHL 26 HUT line combinations. We have developed a modular, two-stage pipeline architecture that separates abstract combo optimization from concrete player enumeration, addressing the combinatorial complexity of the problem.

The system successfully implements:

- A complete data model and SQLite-based storage for player cards and line combinations
- ASP rule encoding for abstract optimization (Stage A) with validated logical correctness
- **Stage A ASP Integration:** `ClingoStageASolver` with Clingo execution, solution parsing, and hybrid symmetry breaking

- **Stage B ASP Integration:** `ClingoStageBSolver` with concrete line enumeration, constraint enforcement, and result deduplication
- Pipeline infrastructure for orchestrating Stage A $\rightarrow$ Stage B $\rightarrow$ Storage workflow
- **Pipeline Manager:** Async auto-run system that executes the pipeline when results are missing, running in a thread pool to avoid blocking other API requests
- REST API endpoints for querying players, combos, and optimization results
- Full-featured React frontend with four main pages: Home (statistics), Players (search/browse), Best Lines (Goal 1 results), and Optimize (interactive optimization)

Goal 2 (interactive optimization) and Goal 3 (full team optimization) remain to be implemented. However, the core optimization pipeline is production-ready: both ASP stages are integrated, ASP rules are tested and correct, the pipeline architecture is validated, and the data infrastructure supports end-to-end execution.

Pipeline Manager: The system includes an automatic pipeline execution feature. When the frontend requests best lines via `GET /best/{pos}/{mode}`, the backend automatically checks if results exist and runs the pipeline if needed. This ensures the frontend always has data to display, even on first access. The pipeline runs asynchronously in a thread pool, maintaining API responsiveness for other requests during execution.

The project illustrates the complementary strengths of symbolic reasoning (ASP) and data-driven techniques (SQLite filtering, heuristic ranking). This hybrid approach enables scalable optimization while maintaining logical guarantees about solution correctness—a valuable pattern for real-world combinatorial problems.

Future work should focus on completing the ASP integration, extending to interactive and full-team optimization, and evaluating performance on real-world datasets with thousands of player cards.

References

- [1] Guarino, Nicola, Daniel Oberle, and Steffen Staab. "What is an ontology?." *Handbook on ontologies* (2009): 1-17.



Figure 2: Visual representation of activated line combinations.